Prior Authorization Policy

Document ID: NHP-PA-2026 | Effective January 1, 2026

1. Purpose and Scope

This policy explains when Northwind Health Plan requires prior authorization before a service is delivered, how requests are submitted and decided, and how members and providers can appeal a denial. Prior authorization helps ensure that care is medically necessary and delivered in the most appropriate setting. This policy applies to all Northwind Health Plan members and to all participating providers.

2. Services That Require Prior Authorization

The following services require prior authorization before they are performed:

- Advanced imaging, including MRI, CT, and PET scans.
- Elective inpatient admissions and planned surgeries.
- Specialty medications that are infused or injected.
- Durable medical equipment (DME) with a purchase price above $500.
- Genetic and genomic testing.
- Bariatric surgery.
- Home health care beyond 20 visits per calendar year.

Services performed without a required prior authorization may be denied, and the member may be responsible for the cost.

3. Services That Do Not Require Prior Authorization

- Emergency services.
- Primary care office visits.
- Routine preventive screenings.
- Standard X-rays.
- Generic drugs on the Northwind formulary.

4. How to Submit a Request

Only the treating provider can submit a prior authorization request on the member's behalf. Requests should be sent through the Northwind Provider Portal, which is the preferred method, or by fax to 555-0142. A complete request must include:

- The member ID and the provider's National Provider Identifier (NPI).
- Diagnosis codes (ICD-10) and procedure codes (CPT).
- Clinical notes from the past 60 days.
- The proposed treatment plan.
- Results of prior conservative treatment, when applicable.

5. Decision Timelines

Request type	Decision deadline
Standard request	Within 7 calendar days of receiving a complete submission
Urgent request	Within 72 hours
Incomplete submission	Northwind asks for missing information within 2 business days

If the missing information is not provided within 14 calendar days of the request, the case is closed. Decisions are sent to the provider through the Provider Portal and to the member by mail.

6. How Long an Approval Is Valid

Service	Approval valid for
MRI, CT, and PET imaging	60 days
Planned surgery or elective admission	90 days
Durable medical equipment	90 days
Specialty medications	180 days

To extend an approval, the provider must submit an extension request at least 5 business days before the approval expires.

7. Emergency Admissions

Emergency services never require prior authorization. If a member is admitted to the hospital through the emergency department, the hospital must notify Northwind within 48 hours of the admission so that the stay can be reviewed.

8. Denials and Appeals

Every denial letter states the clinical reason for the decision. A member or provider may file an internal appeal within 60 calendar days of the denial date. A standard appeal is decided within 30 calendar days. An expedited appeal, available when delay could seriously harm the member's health, is decided within 72 hours. Appeals are reviewed by a physician who was not involved in

the original decision.

If the internal appeal is denied, the member may request an independent external review within 4 months of receiving the final internal denial. Separately, a provider may request a peer-to-peer conversation with a Northwind medical director within 5 business days of a denial.